

2026

Social & Modern Studies

Grade 9 NCE — **Paper 3 of 4**

Focus: Environment & Sustainability • Human Rights

Duration: 2 hours **Total Marks:** 100

Candidate Name: _____

Class / Form: _____ Index No.: _____

Instructions to Candidates

1. This paper has **four sections**: A, B, C, and D.
2. Answer **ALL** questions in Sections A, B, and D.
3. In Section C, answer **ALL THREE** structured questions.
4. Write your answers in the spaces provided.
5. For Section A, tick (✓) **ONE** box only per question.
6. Use blue or black ink. Pencil may be used for diagrams only.
7. The marks for each question are shown in brackets [].
8. Calculators are **NOT** permitted.

Section	A — MCQ	B — Source	C — Structured	D — Essay	Total
Maximum marks	20	30	30	20	100
Marks scored					

SECTION A — Multiple Choice Questions [20 marks — 1 mark each] Tick ONE box only per question.

1. Sustainable development is defined as development that: [1]
- ☐ A Increases GDP as quickly as possible
 - ☐ B Meets the needs of the present without compromising future generations' ability to meet theirs
 - ☐ C Focuses only on environmental protection, regardless of economic costs
 - ☐ D Is managed exclusively by international organisations
2. Which gas is the MAIN contributor to the enhanced greenhouse effect causing climate change? [1]
- ☐ A Oxygen (O₂)
 - ☐ B Nitrogen (N₂)
 - ☐ C Carbon dioxide (CO₂)
 - ☐ D Hydrogen (H₂)
3. Which of the following is an effect of climate change that particularly threatens small island states like Mauritius? [1]
- ☐ A Increase in snowfall and glacial expansion
 - ☐ B Rising sea levels and increased frequency of extreme weather events
 - ☐ C Cooling of ocean temperatures leading to more fish stocks
 - ☐ D Expansion of forests and increased biodiversity
4. The Paris Agreement (2015) aimed to: [1]
- ☐ A Eliminate nuclear weapons worldwide
 - ☐ B Limit global temperature rise to well below 2°C above pre-industrial levels
 - ☐ C Create a single global government to manage environmental issues
 - ☐ D Establish free trade in renewable energy technologies
5. Biodiversity refers to: [1]
- ☐ A The variety of all living organisms in a given area
 - ☐ B The number of human cultures present in a region
 - ☐ C The amount of farmland available for agriculture
 - ☐ D The range of genetic characteristics within one species only

6. Coral bleaching in Mauritius's lagoons is mainly caused by: [1]
- ☐ A Overfishing and trawling
 - ☐ B Rising ocean temperatures and ocean acidification linked to climate change
 - ☐ C Increased rainfall and freshwater runoff
 - ☐ D Reduction in tourist numbers
7. A renewable source of energy is one that: [1]
- ☐ A Is derived from fossil fuels found underground
 - ☐ B Can be naturally replenished and does not run out, such as solar or wind energy
 - ☐ C Produces the highest amount of energy per unit of fuel
 - ☐ D Is produced only in developed countries
8. The term 'carbon footprint' refers to: [1]
- ☐ A The physical area of land covered by coal mines
 - ☐ B The total amount of greenhouse gases produced by a person, organisation, or product
 - ☐ C The rate at which forests are being cut down
 - ☐ D The number of cars owned per household
9. Which of the following is a strategy Mauritius has adopted to address plastic pollution? [1]
- ☐ A Increasing the production of single-use plastics for export
 - ☐ B Banning single-use plastics such as bags and straws
 - ☐ C Importing more plastic products to meet consumer demand
 - ☐ D Burning plastic waste to generate electricity
10. The 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) were adopted by the United Nations in: [1]
- ☐ A 2000
 - ☐ B 2012
 - ☐ C 2015
 - ☐ D 2020
11. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) was adopted by the United Nations in: [1]
- ☐ A 1945
 - ☐ B 1948
 - ☐ C 1966
 - ☐ D 1989

12. Which of the following is a CIVIL and POLITICAL right under the UDHR? [1]
- ☐ A The right to work and fair wages
 - ☐ B The right to education
 - ☐ C The right to social security
 - ☐ D Freedom from torture and cruel treatment
13. Human rights are described as 'universal' because: [1]
- ☐ A They apply only to citizens of democratic countries
 - ☐ B They can be taken away by governments in times of emergency
 - ☐ C They belong to every human being regardless of nationality, race, religion, or gender
 - ☐ D They are enforced by a world police force
14. The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC) declares that: [1]
- ☐ A Children should work to contribute to their family's income
 - ☐ B All children under 18 have rights to protection, participation, and provision
 - ☐ C Children's rights are solely the responsibility of their parents
 - ☐ D Only children in developing countries need special protection
15. Which of the following is an example of a human rights violation? [1]
- ☐ A A government building new schools for all children
 - ☐ B A country holding free and fair elections every five years
 - ☐ C Detention of journalists without trial for reporting on the government
 - ☐ D A court acquitting a defendant due to insufficient evidence
16. The International Criminal Court (ICC) was established to: [1]
- ☐ A Resolve trade disputes between member states
 - ☐ B Prosecute individuals accused of genocide, war crimes, and crimes against humanity
 - ☐ C Manage the United Nations budget
 - ☐ D Provide aid to countries affected by natural disasters
17. Civil society organisations that monitor and report human rights abuses include: [1]
- ☐ A The World Trade Organization and International Monetary Fund
 - ☐ B Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch
 - ☐ C The African Development Bank and SADC Secretariat
 - ☐ D NATO and the European Union

18. 'Indivisibility of human rights' means that:

[1]

- ☐ A Human rights belong only to individuals, not groups
- ☐ B All rights are equally important and the violation of one right affects the enjoyment of others
- ☐ C Only civil and political rights are legally enforceable
- ☐ D Human rights cannot be discussed or debated

19. Which of the following best describes the concept of 'environmental justice'?

[1]

- ☐ A The idea that only wealthy nations should pay for environmental protection
- ☐ B The principle that environmental benefits and burdens should be distributed fairly across society
- ☐ C The belief that economic development is more important than environmental protection
- ☐ D Punishment of companies that pollute through criminal law

20. The right to a clean and healthy environment was formally recognised by the UN General Assembly in:

[1]

- ☐ A 1972
- ☐ B 1992
- ☐ C 2010
- ☐ D 2022

SECTION B — Source-Based Questions [30 marks] Answer ALL questions in this section.

SOURCE A

As a small island developing state (SIDS) located in the Indian Ocean, Mauritius is highly vulnerable to the effects of climate change. Sea-level rise of 3–5mm per year threatens low-lying coastal areas and the country's world-famous beaches and lagoons. Increased intensity of tropical cyclones poses risks to infrastructure, agriculture, and tourism. Ocean warming and acidification have led to coral bleaching events, destroying reef ecosystems that support fish populations and protect coastlines from wave erosion. Mauritius is also grappling with plastic pollution in its marine environment, deforestation of indigenous forests for agriculture and development, and the spread of invasive plant and animal species that threaten its unique flora and fauna. Despite contributing less than 0.01% of global greenhouse gas emissions, Mauritius faces some of the most severe impacts of climate change. The government has committed to achieving 60% renewable energy by 2030 as part of its climate strategy.

Adapted from: Ministry of Environment, Mauritius National Climate Change Adaptation Strategy, 2024

21.

- (a) Using Source A, identify **TWO** environmental challenges facing Mauritius related to climate change. [2]

- (b) Using Source A, explain why it is considered unjust that Mauritius suffers severely from climate change despite contributing very little to global greenhouse gas emissions. [4]

- (c) Using Source A and your own knowledge, suggest **TWO** strategies Mauritius could adopt to protect its environment and reduce its vulnerability to climate change.

[4]

SOURCE B

Table: Mauritius — Selected Environmental Indicators (2023)

Indicator	Value
Share of electricity from renewable sources	23%
Renewable energy target by 2030	60%
Forest cover as % of land area	17%
Marine protected area (% of territorial waters)	28%
CO ₂ emissions per capita (tonnes/year)	3.4
Coral reef area affected by bleaching events	~40%
Single-use plastics ban implemented	Yes (2020)

Source: Statistics Mauritius / Ministry of Environment, 2023

22.

- (a) Using Source B, calculate the percentage-point increase in renewable energy that Mauritius needs to achieve to meet its 2030 target. Show your working.

[2]

- (b) Using Source B, identify **TWO** pieces of evidence that show Mauritius is taking action to protect its environment. For each, explain what action has been taken and why it matters.

[4]

- (c) Using Source B, discuss whether the data suggests that Mauritius has done enough to address its environmental challenges. Give a justified response.

[4]

SOURCE C

"Article 1: All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood.

Article 3: Everyone has the right to life, liberty and the security of person.

Article 5: No one shall be subjected to torture or to cruel, inhuman or degrading treatment or punishment.

Article 26: Everyone has the right to education. Education shall be free, at least in the elementary and fundamental stages. Education shall be directed to the full development of the human personality and to the strengthening of respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms."

Source: United Nations Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), 1948. Selected Articles.

23.

- (a) Using Source C (Article 1), what does 'equal in dignity and rights' mean for how people should treat one another?

[2]

- (b) Using Source C, choose **TWO** articles and explain how each right is relevant to the lives of young people in Mauritius today.

[4]

- (c) Using Source C and your own knowledge, explain why the UDHR is considered a landmark document in the history of human rights. What are its limitations as an enforcement mechanism? [4]

SECTION C — Structured Essay Questions [30 marks] Answer ALL THREE questions.

- 24. Describe the main environmental challenges facing Mauritius and explain the causes of each challenge.**

[10]

Your answer should address: climate change and rising sea levels; coral reef degradation; plastic pollution; deforestation; and invasive species.



- 25. Explain the concept of sustainable development and evaluate how effectively Mauritius is applying it in its economic and environmental policies.**

[10]

Consider: the definition of sustainable development; Mauritius's renewable energy commitments; environmental regulations; the tensions between development and conservation.



26. Discuss the importance of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) and explain how human rights are protected in Mauritius.

[10]

Refer to: the content and significance of the UDHR; how the Mauritian Constitution protects rights; specific rights protected; any challenges to human rights in Mauritius.

SECTION D — Extended Writing and Evaluation [20 marks] Answer the COMPULSORY question below.

- 27. "Environmental sustainability and economic development are incompatible goals for small island developing states like Mauritius."**

[20]

Using your knowledge and the evidence from Section B, write a well-organised essay in which you:

- Explain what is meant by environmental sustainability and economic development
- Argue that environmental sustainability and economic development can conflict, using examples from Mauritius
- Argue that environmental sustainability and economic development can be compatible and mutually reinforcing, using examples from Mauritius
- Reach a justified conclusion about whether the two goals are incompatible for SIDS like Mauritius

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Mark Scheme — Paper 3: Environment & Sustainability / Human Rights

This mark scheme provides **indicative content**. Credit any well-reasoned response that demonstrates knowledge and understanding. Exact wording is not required.

Section A — MCQ Answers

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1. B — Meets present needs without compromising future
2. C — Carbon dioxide
3. B — Rising sea levels and extreme weather
4. B — Limit temperature rise to below 2°C
5. A — Variety of all living organisms
6. B — Rising ocean temperatures and acidification
7. B — Naturally replenished e.g. solar/wind
8. B — Total greenhouse gases produced
9. B — Banning single-use plastics
10. C — 2015 | 11. B — 1948
12. D — Freedom from torture
13. C — Belong to every human being regardless of nationality etc.
14. B — All children under 18 have rights to protection, participation, provision
15. C — Detention of journalists without trial
16. B — Prosecute individuals for genocide/war crimes
17. B — Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch
18. B — All rights equally important and interdependent
19. B — Fair distribution of environmental benefits and burdens
20. D — 2022 |
|---|--|

Q	Indicative Content	Marks
21(a)	Any TWO from Source A: sea-level rise (3–5mm/year); increased intensity of tropical cyclones; coral bleaching due to ocean warming and acidification; plastic pollution; deforestation; invasive species. Award 1 mark each.	2
21(b)	Mauritius contributes less than 0.01% of global emissions yet faces severe impacts (injustice/disproportionality); this raises questions of environmental justice — those who contribute least to climate change suffer most; moral responsibility of large emitters to support SIDS; links to right to development and right to a healthy environment. Award marks for understanding of injustice and appropriate use of source evidence.	4
21(c)	Any TWO strategies with explanation: invest in renewable energy (solar, wind) to reduce fossil fuel dependence; marine conservation and coral reef restoration programmes; ban on single-use plastics; reforestation of indigenous species; sea walls and coastal protection infrastructure; international climate diplomacy (loss and damage funding); diversify tourism to reduce coral reef pressure. Award 2 marks per strategy: 1 for naming, 1 for explaining how it helps.	4
22(a)	Target (60%) – Current (23%) = 37 percentage points . Award 1 mark for method, 1 mark for correct answer.	2
22(b)	Any TWO from Source B: plastic ban (2020) — reduces marine pollution protecting reefs and marine life; 28% marine protected areas — preserves biodiversity and fish stocks; 60% renewable energy target — reduces fossil fuel dependence and emissions. Award 2 marks per point: 1 for identifying, 1 for explaining significance.	4

22(c)	<i>Action taken:</i> marine protection (28%), plastic ban, renewable target. <i>Not enough:</i> only 23% renewable so far (target 37pp gap); ~40% coral bleaching; CO ₂ per capita still 3.4 tonnes; forest cover at 17% still limited. A balanced, evidence-based response should reach a justified conclusion — award marks for using specific data to support the argument.	4
23(a)	No person should be treated as less important or less deserving of respect than another; all people have the same inherent worth regardless of background; this means discrimination is wrong and people should treat each other with respect. Award 2 marks for a clear, thoughtful explanation.	2
23(b)	Art. 3 (life, liberty, security): relevant to safety from crime, police protection, right not to be arbitrarily imprisoned. Art. 5 (freedom from torture): ensures students cannot be physically abused at school; protection in custody. Art. 26 (education): Mauritius provides free education to Grade 9 (NCE), relevant to all students. Award 2 marks per article: 1 for identifying the right, 1 for explaining Mauritius relevance.	4
23(c)	<i>Landmark:</i> first international document establishing universal human rights; adopted 1948 after WWII atrocities; moral standard; influenced national constitutions including Mauritius. <i>Limitations:</i> not legally binding (Declaration, not Treaty); no enforcement mechanism; relies on political will; states may ratify but fail to implement; cultural relativism debates; powerful states sometimes exempt themselves. Award marks for accurate historical context plus balanced assessment of limitations.	4
24	<i>Band 4 (8–10):</i> Detailed description of at least 4 challenges with clear causes; evidence from Mauritius; well-organised. <i>Content:</i> climate change — burning fossil fuels globally raises temperatures; sea-level rise threatens coastlines; cyclone intensification; coral bleaching — ocean warming; plastic pollution — tourism, consumer waste; deforestation — agriculture, development; invasive species — historically introduced for agriculture. Strong answers show understanding of causes, not just symptoms.	10
25	<i>Definition:</i> meeting present needs without compromising future generations (Brundtland 1987). <i>Mauritius examples:</i> renewable energy target (60% by 2030); marine protected areas; plastic ban; National Environmental Policy. <i>Tensions:</i> tourism development vs. reef conservation; fishing industry vs. marine protection; economic growth pressures vs. emission reduction. <i>Evaluation:</i> Mauritius has made progress but targets still not met; international finance needed. Higher marks reward evaluation and specific examples.	10
26	<i>UDHR:</i> adopted 1948; 30 articles; civil/political and economic/social/cultural rights; moral standard. <i>Mauritius Constitution:</i> Chapter II Bill of Rights mirrors UDHR — freedom of expression, freedom from torture, fair trial. <i>Specific rights protected:</i> right to vote, freedom of religion, right to education. <i>Challenges:</i> domestic violence, gender discrimination, migrant worker conditions, freedom of press debates. Award higher marks for specific Mauritian examples and evaluative balance.	10
27	Extended essay — 20 marks. Level 4 (16–20): Clear definitions; strong balanced argument with specific examples of conflict (tourism development vs. reef, economic growth vs.	20

emissions, fishing vs. marine protection) AND compatibility (eco-tourism, renewable energy creating jobs, green economy); evaluative conclusion that these goals need not be incompatible if well-managed, with caveats for SIDS challenges. Level 3 (11–15): Good argument, mostly balanced. Level 2 (6–10): Some relevant content, limited analysis. Level 1 (1–5): Very limited.
